

THE THREE FORMS

Finding the Shape of the Lie

ONE LIE, THREE SHAPES

Resource 1 told you what you're looking for: the self-referential verdict your character's formative wound produced. But a lie stated in the wrong shape is hard to test, and harder to lock to a wound. Every lie this method has found resolves into one of three structural forms.

Knowing the three in advance means you are not inventing a sentence structure in the middle of your coaching session. You are recognizing which of three known shapes your character's lie already has — and, often, testing more than one before you find the shape that fits without strain.

O1

IDENTITY STATEMENT

A declarative verdict about what the character fundamentally is. The most direct of the three forms — it names the self-definition the wound produced without disguising it as anything else.

STRUCTURE “I am ___” or “I am someone who ___.”

USE WHEN The wound produced a conclusion about the character's inherent worth, capability, or fundamental nature.

O2

WORLDVIEW DISTORTION

A statement that sounds like an observation about the world but is actually a verdict about the self, projected outward. The character describes how people or circumstances behave in terms that are really about what they believe they are owed, or worth.

STRUCTURE “No one can ___” / “People only ___” / “The world requires ___.”

USE WHEN The lie is hiding inside what sounds like a claim about reality rather than a claim about the self.

03

FALSE IMPERATIVE

A command the character issues to themselves — the behavioral rule the lie generates. This form explains the compulsion directly: not what the character is, but what they must do, or must never do, to keep the lie from being confirmed.

STRUCTURE “I must ___, or else ___” / “I cannot ___.”

USE WHEN The lie shows up most clearly as an obligation the character cannot refuse without unbearable internal cost.

ONE CHARACTER, THREE FORMS

A woman grew up in a household where love was conditional on usefulness — valued when she helped, invisible when she wasn't. No single catastrophic event. Years of a pattern that crystallized into certainty.

Anchor behavior (Lesson 1): She takes on other people's burdens before being asked, and refuses help for herself.

Hidden truth (Lesson 2): “I am only safe when I am needed.”

Formative wound (Lesson 3): The accumulated experience of becoming invisible the moment she stopped being useful.

Testing all three forms against the same wound is itself part of the diagnosis — the form that requires no argument to justify is the one that's right.

FORM 01 · IDENTITY STATEMENT

“I have no intrinsic worth. My value exists only in what I do for others.”

Most precise for this character. It names exactly what the wound taught her about herself — not about the world, but about what she is when no one needs her.

FORM 02 · WORLDVIEW DISTORTION

“People only stay when you make yourself indispensable to them.”

Looks like a statement about people. It is actually a verdict about her own worthiness to be kept without earning it.

FORM 03 · FALSE IMPERATIVE

“I must make myself useful to everyone around me, or I will be abandoned.”

Explains the compulsion — why she cannot accept help, cannot rest, and turns every relationship into a transaction she has to sustain through output.

The identity statement is the most precise form for this character. It is the belief that makes all three anchor behavior instances feel not just likely, but inevitable.

THE WOUND-TO-LIE LOCK

Because of this wound, my character concluded _____ about themselves.

This is the Lesson 4 counterpart to the causal locks from Lessons 2 and 3. Complete it with the form you've chosen, then read it back. The lock holds when the conclusion about the self feels as inevitable as the conclusion about the world did in Lesson 2 — when no argument is required, only recognition.

If you find yourself explaining why the wound would produce this self-belief, the lie is not specific enough yet, or you've chosen the wrong form. The right lie, in its right form, belongs only to this character, from this wound, with this history. Push until it is that particular.

WHAT COMES NEXT

*Not every form will fit your character equally well — and a lie that needs an argument to justify its form probably isn't specific enough yet. The next resource, *Four Signs the Lie Isn't Specific Enough Yet*, is the diagnostic check for exactly that problem.*